further the interests of one political party, one person, and one family, in a manner totally at variance with the larger interests of the nation. It was becoming extremely difficult for me to internalize that. My conscience would not allow me to compromise with that and I had to take a decision, sooner rather than later.

A person in my position had limited options to deal with such a dilemma. There was no question of silencing my conscience for the sake of my job. I could not have acted as a whistleblower either. The leaked information could have easily been traced back to me, leading to my summary dismissal, possibly with a trumped-up charge of being an Inter-Services Intelligence (ISI) agent or a Khalistan activist. It would have been my word against theirs. The ever-obliging media would have torn me apart. Second, I could have resigned from service and joined a political party. But I had seen what had happened to my father-in-law, Sardar Swaran Singh, former external affairs minister and a close confidant of Indira Gandhi. He was made to resign from her cabinet in November 1975 because of his opposition to the imposition of National Emergency in June that year. I was small fry compared to him.

The third option for me was to resign from service and return to teaching, which I still loved. But pay scales, the main reason I had switched careers to the Indian Police Service (IPS) in 1964, had not improved much over the years. So I opted for the only sensible and safe choice available to me. I quietly delinked myself from the said activities and moved over to an analysis division within the R&AW, where my job was confined to reading and writing papers/reports, conducting research work, and developing short- to long-term strategic analysis.

And that was what I did on my return from my third operational visit to the US in the first week of October 1983. I shared my views on the matter with Director G.C. (Gary) Saxena, my highly understanding boss, who listened to me patiently, but incredulously, at my frank expression of views. In the end he agreed to my request to relieve me of the charge of the two highly sensitive divisions I was handling and additional operational work related to Punjab.

Those who have had to face a similar dilemma in their lives will realize how difficult it is to live with it without sharing some of your